

LIWELILE IMPUMELELO COMMUNITY CENTRE

JAPAN PARTNERSHIP RESEARCH LOG

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Prepared by: International Partnerships Coordinator

Status: Active Research Document

SECTION A: RESEARCH STRATEGY OVERVIEW

A1: Target Sectors for Japan Partnership

Priority	Sector	Focus Area	Rationale
1	Animation & Content Creation	Storytelling, character design, production techniques	Direct alignment with Programme 4 vision for "telling South African stories"
2	IP Licensing & Merchandising	Rights acquisition for Japanese characters	Potential revenue stream and creative collaboration
3	Creative Industry Development	Studio practices, distribution, global market access	Building sustainable creative industry in South Africa
4	Youth Cultural Exchange	Anime/manga as engagement tool for youth programmes	Connecting Programme 3 youth to creative opportunities

A2: Research Channels

Channel	Target	Method	Status
JETRO Johannesburg	Trade/commercial attaché	Formal letter, meeting request	☐

Channel	Target	Method	Status
Comic Con Africa	Industry connections, licensing seminars	Event participation, networking	☐
Japanese Embassy Pretoria	Cultural attaché	Formal introduction	☐
Arc & Beyond / TAIDO Project	Sony-backed animation initiative	Direct outreach	☐
CBLA (Character Brand Licensing Association)	Licensing experts	Via JETRO introductions	☐

SECTION B: RELEVANT SEARCH RESULTS – ANALYSIS

B1: JETRO South Africa – Active Creative Industry Bridge

Source	Key Finding	Relevance to LICC
JETRO South Africa (Aug 2025)	JETRO and Comic Con Africa partnership continues to connect Southern Africa with Japanese companies through pop culture and IP licensing. 2025 focus shifts to "anime fan as an important part of the business ecosystem." "Made in Japan Collection" gaming station featured 19 Japanese companies with over 30 titles.	HIGH – JETRO is the official government-backed gateway to Japanese creative industries. Their active SA presence and focus on anime business makes them a primary contact.

Source	Key Finding	Relevance to LICC
Japan Pop Culture Connect 2025 (Sept 2025)	JETRO Johannesburg and Comic Con Africa hosted Japan Pop Culture Connect (JPCC) – a hybrid event for South African businesses interested in Japanese IP licensing. Featured Character Brand Licensing Association (CBLA) from Japan providing insights on licensing processes. Panel discussed import growth (3x since working with JETRO). SATAGA (anti-counterfeiting org) advised on IP protection.	HIGHEST – This is exactly the kind of event LICC should attend/engage with. CBLA contact could provide direct guidance on licensing Japanese characters.
Comic Con Africa & JETRO Partnership (2024)	Partnership resulted in 58 meetings facilitated, 18 success cases across content licensing, consumer product licensing, and licensed product imports, with expected deal value of R8.5 million.	HIGH – Proven track record of successful business matching. Contact: Ruan Botha, Project Coordinator for JETRO Johannesburg.

B2: TAIDO Project – Sony-Backed Animation Initiative

Source	Key Finding	Relevance to LICC
Taido Project Drives Africa's Animation Push (Nov 2025)	AnimaxFYB Studios (Ghana) and Japan's Arc & Beyond (established by Sony to address global social challenges) launched Taido Project. Arc & Beyond's Miyuki Kitabatake: "Japan has fewer animators and our population is declining, but we still need to produce world-class animation. Africa has millions of talented people with unique stories. That is why we are here." Goal: not replicate Japanese anime but	HIGHEST MATCH – Direct partnership opportunity. Sony-backed initiative explicitly seeking African creative partners. The declining animator workforce in Japan creates opportunity for skills transfer and co-production.

Source	Key Finding	Relevance to LICC
	ignite original African content with African IP ownership.	
TAIDO Project: Sony-backed plan to co- produce African animation (Nov 2025)	Arc & Beyond (Sony Group non-profit) focused on solving global challenges through creative collaboration. Francis Brown (AnimaxFYB): "In 2023, global animation industry made over \$300 billion, Africa contributed \$15.5 billion, yet none stayed here because we were only consuming. Taido is here to change that." African creators retain 100% IP ownership. Miyuki Kitabatake: "We don't want to make 'Japanese-style' animation. We want to support authentic African stories, created by African studios".	HIGHEST – Clear value proposition: skills transfer, production pipeline development, distribution access, while African creators keep IP. Perfect alignment with LICC's vision of telling South African stories.

Source	Key Finding	Relevance to LICC
Ghana eyes \$895bn global animation market with Japan partnership (March 2026)	Japan's Ambassador to Ghana, Hiroshi Yoshimoto: "TAIDO Project aims to promote African countries' stories to the world while fostering the animation industry to create employment opportunities locally." Productions blend African storytelling with Japanese technical expertise. Global animation market projected to reach \$895 billion by 2034.	HIGH – Demonstrates Japanese government-level support for animation partnerships. Market size projections validate the opportunity.

B3: Japanese Studio Interest in African Content

Source	Key Finding	Relevance to LICC
Toei and South African Company联手打造黑人武士弥助史诗电影 (April 2025)	Toei (Japan's leading animation/film studio) and South Africa's Pambili Media signed agreement to co-develop feature film "Yasuke: Butterfly's Path" about 16th-century African samurai. Directed by South African filmmaker Mandela Dube. Toei Vice President Yuji Kojima: "This collaboration is not only a reinterpretation of history but also demonstrates Toei's commitment to continuous innovation".	HIGH – Major Japanese studio (Toei produced Dragon Ball, One Piece) actively co-producing with South Africa. Pambili Media is a direct local contact with existing Japanese partnership experience.

B4: Broader Japan-SA Cooperation Context

Source	Key Finding	Relevance to LICC
Mahlobo embarks on	Water and Sanitation Deputy Minister Mahlobo visited Japan to	MEDIUM – Demonstrates strong government-to-

Source	Key Finding	Relevance to LICC
strategic visit to Japan (Feb 2026)	strengthen bilateral cooperation. JICA (Japan International Cooperation Agency) supports SA with capacity building and skills transfer. 10 SA officials per year receive specialised training in Japan. Japan positioned as "strategic technical partner" for SA.	government cooperation framework. JICA's focus on skills transfer and training could potentially extend to creative industries.

B5: University Research Partnerships

Source	Key Finding	Relevance to LICC
African universities to benefit from research partnership (Aug 2025)	JICA supports research partnership between Egypt-Japan University (E-JUST), Jomo Kenyatta University (Kenya), and Stellenbosch University (SA). Focus on water, food systems, engineering. Japan wants to expand initiative and bring more universities on board. Dr Tanaka Akihiko (JICA President) reaffirmed Japan's commitment to strengthening "historic partnership".	LOW-MEDIUM – Not directly animation-focused but shows JICA's broader education and skills development mandate. Stellenbosch University connection could be explored.

SECTION C: POTENTIAL PARTNERS – SHORTLIST

C1: Highest Priority (Direct Match, Active Programmes)

Company/Organisation	Sector	Location	Contact	Partnership Angle	Status
Arc & Beyond (Sony Group)	Animation development, skills transfer	Japan (with Africa focus)	Miyuki Kitabatake, Project Leader	TAIDO Project offers mentorship, technical support, co-production opportunities while African creators retain 100% IP ownership	To Contact
AnimaxFYB Studios	Animation production (African partner)	Accra, Ghana	Francis Y. Brown, Creative Director	Lead African partner in TAIDO Project; could provide mentorship and share experience of Japanese partnership	To Contact

Company/Organisation	Sector	Location	Contact	Partnership Angle	Status
Pambili Media	Film/Content production	South Africa	Mandela Dube, Director	Already co-producing with Toei; direct local experience with Japanese studio partnership	To Research

C2: High Priority (Government/Trade Facilitators)

Organisation	Focus	Location	Contact	Partnership Angle	Status
JETRO Johannesburg	Trade promotion, business matching	Johannesburg	Ruan Botha, Project Coordinator	Gateway to Japanese companies ; facilitates licensing meetings; track record of 75+ meetings, 32 success cases	To Contact
CBLA (Character Brand Licensing)	IP licensing expertise	Japan	Kazuo Rikukawa (featured at JPCC)	Expert guidance on licensing Japanese	Via JETRO

Organisatio n	Focus	Location	Contact	Partnership Angle	Statu s
Associatio n)				IP; could advise LICC on rights acquisition	
Japanese Embassy Pretoria	Cultural attaché	Pretoria	Ambassad or's office	Governme nt-level introductio ns; cultural exchange programme s	To Conta ct

C3: Medium Priority (Learning/Knowledge Resources)

Organisatio n	Focus	Locatio n	Contact	Partnership Angle	Statu s
SATAGA	Anti- counterfeitin g, IP protection	Japan	[Via JETRO]	Advised on IP protection at JPCC; could help LICC understand legal framework s	Via JETRO
Toei Animation	Major studio (Dragon Ball, One Piece)	Japan	Yuji Kojima, Vice Presiden t	Already partnering with SA (Pambili Media);	Monitor

Organisatio n	Focus	Locatio n	Contact	Partnership Angle	Statu s
				potential for broader engagemen t	

SECTION D: CONTACT STRATEGY

D1: Immediate Actions (Next 30 Days)

Target	Action	Responsible	Deadline	Status
JETRO Johannesburg (Ruan Botha)	Email introduction expressing interest in creative industry partnerships; request information on upcoming JPCC events	Chair + Intl Coordinator	31 March 2026	☐
Arc & Beyond (Miyuki Kitabatake)	Draft outreach email introducing LICC's vision for South African storytelling and interest in TAIDO Project	Chair + Intl Coordinator	31 March 2026	☐
AnimaxFYB Studios (Francis Brown)	LinkedIn connection request with personalised note; express interest in learning from their TAIDO experience	Chair	31 March 2026	☐

Target	Action	Responsible	Deadline	Status
Pambili Media (Mandela Dube)	Research company contact details and Toei partnership specifics	Intl Coordinator	31 March 2026	☐

D2: Medium-Term Actions (2-3 Months)

Target	Action	Responsible	Timeline
JETRO	Attend any JPCC seminars/events; request business matching meetings	Chair + Intl Coordinator	Next JPCC event
Comic Con Africa 2026	Attend as observer; network with JETRO representatives and potential partners	Chair	September 2026
Arc & Beyond	Follow up on initial contact; explore potential for LICC participation in TAIDO mentorship	Chair	May 2026
Pambili Media	Arrange meeting to discuss their Toei partnership experience	Chair	May 2026

SECTION E: RESEARCH LOG – DETAILED ENTRIES

Entry #001: Arc & Beyond (Sony Group) / TAIDO Project

Field	Details
Date Identified	19 March 2026
Source	Vanguard , The Sun

Field	Details
Organisation Name	Arc & Beyond
Parent	Established by Sony Group to address global social challenges
Sector	Animation development, skills transfer, co-production
Key Contact	Miyuki Kitabatake, Project Leader
Key Facts	• Launched TAIDO Project with AnimaxFYB Studios (Ghana) to develop African animation • Mission: "solve global challenges through creative collaboration" • Response to Japan's declining animator population – looking to Africa for talent • Goal: co-create original African content with African IP ownership • Emphasis: not replicating Japanese anime, but nurturing authentic African stories
Partnership Potential	• Skills transfer and mentorship for LICC's creative track • Co-production opportunities • Access to Japanese production expertise and distribution networks • African creators retain 100% IP ownership
Action Status	Research contact email; prepare outreach
Notes	This is the most direct match – a Sony-backed initiative specifically seeking African creative partners.

Entry #002: AnimaxFYB Studios

Field	Details
Date Identified	19 March 2026
Source	Graphic Online, Vanguard
Organisation Name	AnimaxFYB Studios
Location	Accra, Ghana
Key Contact	Francis Y. Brown, Founder & Creative Director
Key Facts	• One of Africa's leading 2D, 3D and VFX production companies • Lead African partner in TAIDO Project with Arc & Beyond • Won three awards at TAIDO African Animation Awards in Tokyo • Actively building capacity for African creators to compete globally • Francis Brown: "Africa contributed \$15.5 billion to global animation market, but none stayed here because we were only consuming"
Partnership Potential	• Peer learning from an African studio already partnered with Japanese companies • Could provide mentorship or guidance for LICC's creative track • Potential for regional collaboration on animation projects
Action Status	LinkedIn connection to be sent
Notes	As another African organisation navigating Japanese partnership, AnimaxFYB could be an invaluable peer mentor.

Entry #003: JETRO Johannesburg

Field	Details
Date Identified	19 March 2026
Source	JETRO South Africa, LinkedIn
Organisation Name	Japan External Trade Organization (JETRO) Johannesburg
Key Contact	Ruan Botha, Project Coordinator
Key Facts	• Government-related organisation promoting trade and investment between Japan and world • Active South Africa presence with focus on pop culture/IP licensing • Partnership with Comic Con Africa: 75 meetings facilitated, 32 success cases • Hosts Japan Pop Culture Connect (JPCC) seminars for SA businesses • Works with CBLA (Character Brand Licensing Association) to guide businesses through licensing process
Partnership Potential	• Gateway to Japanese companies in creative sector • Access to licensing expertise and business matching • Information on upcoming events and seminars • Potential introductions to CBLA and SATAGA
Action Status	Email introduction to be drafted
Notes	JETRO is the official, government-backed entry point. They have a proven track record of successful business matching.

Entry #004: Pambili Media

Field	Details
Date Identified	19 March 2026
Source	DoNews
Organisation Name	Pambili Media
Location	South Africa
Key Contact	Mandela Dube, Director
Key Facts	• South African production company • Signed agreement with Toei (major Japanese studio) to co-develop feature film "Yasuke: Butterfly's Path" about African samurai • Film directed by Mandela Dube (directed Netflix thriller "Silverton Siege") • Supported by South Africa's Industrial Development Corporation • Project described as "international epic connecting untold history and cross-continental culture"
Partnership Potential	• Direct local experience with Japanese studio partnership • Could provide insights on negotiating with Japanese partners • Potential networking introduction to Toei
Action Status	Research contact details
Notes	This is a South African company that has already done what LICC aspires to do – partner with a major Japanese studio. Invaluable local resource.

Entry #005: CBLA (Character Brand Licensing Association)

Field	Details
Date Identified	19 March 2026
Source	JETRO , LinkedIn
Organisation Name	Character Brand Licensing Association (CBLA)
Location	Japan
Key Contact	Kazuo Rikukawa (featured speaker at JPCC 2024 and 2025)
Key Facts	• Japanese association focused on character licensing • Provided insights at JPCC on "process for licensing Japanese IP" • Expert guidance on how to obtain rights for Japanese characters and anime shows
Partnership Potential	• Expert advice on licensing Japanese IP • Understanding legal frameworks for character merchandising • Potential to license Japanese characters for LICC programmes or merchandise
Action Status	To be approached via JETRO introduction
Notes	Best approached through JETRO introductions rather than direct cold contact.

SECTION F: CONTACT DETAILS – TO RESEARCH

Organisation	Information Needed
Arc & Beyond	Direct email for Miyuki Kitabatake

Organisation	Information Needed
Pambili Media	Phone, email, physical address
Japanese Embassy Pretoria	Cultural attaché contact
CBLA	Official contact details (via JETRO)

SECTION G: RESEARCH LOG MAINTENANCE

Action	Frequency	Responsible
Update contact details	As discovered	Intl Coordinator
Log new outreach attempts	Weekly	Intl Coordinator
Record responses	Immediate	Intl Coordinator
Review priority list	Monthly	Chair + Intl Coordinator
Add new search results	Ongoing	Intl Coordinator

SECTION H: NEXT STEPS SUMMARY

#	Action	Target	Deadline
1	Draft email introduction to JETRO Johannesburg (Ruan Botha)	JETRO	31 March 2026
2	Draft outreach email to Arc & Beyond (Miyuki Kitabatake)	Arc & beyond	31 March 2026

#	Action	Target	Deadline
3	LinkedIn connection to Francis Brown (AnimaxFYB)	AnimaxFYB	31 March 2026
4	Research Pambili Media contact details	Pambili Media	31 March 2026
5	Research 2026 Comic Con Africa dates and JETRO events	JETRO / Comic Con	31 March 2026

END OF JAPAN PARTNERSHIP RESEARCH LOG
